Amer Macaorao Balindong

Sultan Amer Macaorao Balindong (1909–2009) was a Maranao statesman, traditional ruler, and educator from Lanao del Sur in Mindanao, Philippines.

He served as the hereditary **Sultan of Picong**, a title rooted in both Maranao and Maguindanaon royal bloodlines, and as the elected **Municipal Mayor of Malabang** for more than two decades (1953–1974), one of the longest uninterrupted mayoral tenures in the province's history.<ref name="fb_amer">Facebook. Sultan Amer Macaorao Balindong. Photo post. Retrieved from https://www.facebook.com/100046906275159/photos/sultan-amer-macaorao-balindongmunicipal-mayor-of-malabang-lanao-del-sur1953-1974/2967584176593217/</ref>

Balindong is especially remembered for founding Mah'ad Lanao al-Islamia, the region's first formal Arabic and Islamic university, and for maintaining Malabang as a zone of interfaith harmony during a period when violent conflict was tearing through much of Mindanao.

His descendants continue to hold significant positions throughout Lanao del Sur and the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM), making the Balindong family one of the most enduring political dynasties in the Bangsamoro region.

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Lineage and Royal Authority

Sultan Amer was born in Barangay Dapao, Pualas, Lanao del Sur, into a family with deep royal credentials on both Maranao and Maguindanaon sides.

On his paternal side, he was a direct descendant of **Datu Nago**, the 5th *Noni* (a formal noble rank) of *Ranao Ragat*, and further traced his lineage to **Datu Benito Balindong**, a grandson of the founding ancestral figure Balindong, also known as Aradi.<ref name="fb_amer" />

His Maguindanaon connection came through a forebear named **Amatunding**, who married **Potri Gayang**, the sister of the 17th-century Moro hero and sultan **Sultan Muhammad Dipatuan Kudarat**.<ref name="mindanews">MindaNews. (2021, August). Book review: Revolutionary Democrat — The Life and Times

of Pangalian Balindong. Retrieved from https://mindanews.com/mindaviews/2021/08/book-review-revolutionary-democrat-the-life-and-times-of-pangalian-balindong/</ref>

That marriage bound the Balindong lineage to one of the most powerful sultanate networks in precolonial Muslim Mindanao, lending Sultan Amer a legitimacy that stretched well beyond the territorial boundaries of Picong.

He was formally recognized as the *Radia Pangadapun sa Pikong* (the designated royal heir of Picong) before eventually being enthroned as the traditional Sultan of Picong, the municipality now officially known as Picong (formerly Sultan Gumander).<ref name="philatlas">PhilAtlas. Picong, Lanao del Sur. Retrieved from https://www.philatlas.com/mindanao/barmm/lanao-del-sur/picong.html</ref>

Political Career

Election and First Term (1953)

In 1953, Sultan Amer entered the political arena and won the post of **Municipal Mayor of Malabang**, defeating then-incumbent Datu Kakae Delana in a closely watched race.<ref name="mindanews" />

At the time, Malabang was a sprawling territory: it encompassed what are today the separate towns of Balabagan, Kapatagan, and Picong (then still called Sultan Gumander).

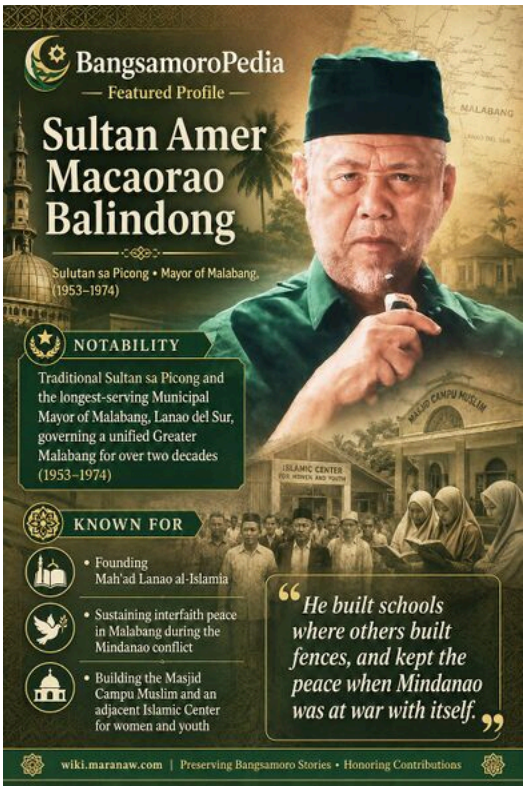
Balindong would win reelection continuously, holding the mayoralty without interruption until 1974, making his tenure one of the longest in the recorded history of Lanao del Sur local governance.

Governance and Interfaith Peace

His administration is widely remembered for two qualities: a sincere commitment to Muslim-Christian integration, and a consistent ability to keep sectarian violence out of his municipality even as Mindanao was engulfed in armed conflict.

The late 1960s and early 1970s brought devastating communal unrest across the region, with the Moro conflict claiming thousands of lives throughout Mindanao.

Malabang, however, remained relatively stable under his watch.

Sultan Amer Macaorao Balindong

Born
1909 Barangay Dapao, Pualas, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Died
2009 (aged approximately 100) Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Ethnicity
Maranao (with Maguindanaon royal lineage)
Traditional Title
Sultan of Picong; *Radia Pangadapun sa Pikong*
Political Office
Municipal Mayor of Malabang, Lanao del Sur (1953–1974)
Religion
Islam
Notable Descendants

Contemporary accounts describe Malabang as having maintained relative interfaith stability during Sultan Balindong's administration, though the municipality, like much of Lanao del Sur, was not without its history of clan feuding and civil unrest.

Atty. Ali Pangalian M. Balindong (son; inaugural Speaker of the Bangsamoro Parliament)
Notability
Traditional Sultan of Picong and one of the longest-serving Municipal Mayors of Malabang, Lanao del Sur, governing a unified Greater Malabang for over two decades (1953–1974)
Known For
Founding Mah'ad Lanao al-Islamia; sustaining interfaith peace in Malabang during the Mindanao conflict; building the Masjid Campu Muslim and an adjacent Islamic Center for women and youth
Pull Quote
"He built schools where others built fences, and kept the peace when Mindanao was at war with itself."

Martial Law and the Partition of Greater Malabang

Sultan Amer's political strength was substantial enough to attract the attention of the Marcos administration.

During the Martial Law period under President Ferdinand Marcos Sr., the national government pursued a policy of fragmenting territories controlled by politically dominant clans in Muslim Mindanao.

Greater Malabang was split into four distinct municipalities through executive and presidential decrees: **Malabang**, **Balabagan**, **Kapatagan**, and **Sultan Gumander** (later officially renamed Picong in 2006).<ref name="wiki_picong">Wikipedia. Picong, Lanao del Sur. Retrieved from https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Picong,_Lanao_del_Sur</ref>

The intent was to dilute the family's localized political authority.

In practice, the partition had the opposite effect: rather than shrinking Balindong influence, it spread family members across more electoral units.

Consecutive generations secured mayorships and legislative seats in multiple partitioned towns, ultimately expanding the dynasty's geographic reach across the restructured political landscape of southern Lanao del Sur.

Educational and Religious Contributions

Mah'ad Lanao al-Islamia

Sultan Amer's most enduring contribution to the region is not political at all: it's educational.

He founded the **Mah'ad Lanao al-Islamia** in Malabang, the first formal institution for Arabic and Islamic higher learning in the area.

In the institution's early years, he personally funded operations and paid faculty salaries from his own pocket, so that local youth could access quality Islamic education at no cost.

The investment produced generational returns.

The university has since produced thousands of Islamic scholars (*Ulamas*) and religious teachers (*Ustadz*), many of whom secured international scholarships in the Middle East and returned to serve communities across Lanao and beyond.

Mah'ad Lanao al-Islamia eventually gained formal recognition from the Philippine Department of Education (DepEd) and was selected as a flagship pilot institution under the **Basic Education Assistance for Mindanao (BEAM)** project, which aimed to bridge traditional Islamic instruction with the national standard curriculum.<ref name="fb_amer" />

Masjid Campu Muslim and Islamic Center

Sultan Amer also directed the construction and funding of the **Masjid Campu Muslim**, which became one of the earliest and most architecturally distinctive mosques along the coastal Lanao region.

Adjacent to the mosque, he built an **Islamic Center** dedicated to the religious education and civic development of women and youth in the broader Malabang community.

Together, the two facilities formed a hub of faith, learning, and public service that remains a landmark of his governance.

Death and Legacy

Sultan Amer Macaorao Balindong passed away in **2009** at approximately 100 years of age, leaving behind a political and cultural legacy that remains visible across Lanao del Sur and the BARMM today.<ref name="fb_amer" /><ref name="mindanews" />

His eldest son, **Atty. Ali Pangalian M. Balindong** (1940–2025), carried the family's tradition of public service into some of the most consequential chapters in Bangsamoro history.

Pangalian served as a delegate to the 1971 Philippine Constitutional Convention, acted as legal counsel to the Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF) during the landmark 1976 Tripoli Agreement, won multiple terms as Representative of Lanao del Sur's 2nd District, and rose to Deputy Speaker of the Philippine House of Representatives.<ref name="bangsamoro_gov">Bangsamoro Government. Speaker Pangalian Balindong: A dreamer for peace, defender of Bangsamoro. Retrieved from https://bangsamoro.gov.ph/news/latest-news/speaker-pangalian-balindong-a-dreamer-for-peace-defender-of-bangsamoro/</ref>

Most notably, Pangalian became the inaugural **Speaker of the Bangsamoro Parliament**, a post he held until his passing in October 2025, cementing the Balindong name at the highest level of Bangsamoro governance.<ref name="wiki_pangalian">Wikipedia. Pangalian Balindong. Retrieved from https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pangalian_Balindong</ref>

Other descendants continue to serve across the region: former Malabang Mayor Amir "Gary" Balindong, Mayor Amin D. Balindong, Picong Mayor Mesron D. Balindong, and Bangsamoro Member of Parliament Ahmad Amir A. Balindong all hold or have held executive and legislative positions within Lanao del Sur and the BARMM.<ref name="lanaodelsur">Lanao del Sur Official Website. Oath-taking of Malabang and Picong officials. Retrieved from https://lanaodelsur.gov.ph/oath-taking-of-malabang-and-picong-officials/</ref><ref name="barmm_parliament">BARMM Parliament. Member of Parliament: Balindong, Ahmad Amir A. Retrieved from https://parliament.bangsamoro.gov.ph/member-parliament/balindong-ahmad-amir-a/</ref>

Sultan Amer built his legacy on three pillars: the traditional authority of a sultan who commanded deep communal respect, the political resolve of a mayor who chose peace over partisanship, and the educational foresight of a founder who invested in Bangsamoro youth before the state ever did.

Across all three, he delivered.

References

- Raw photo credit: **Bilangatao Guwani (https://www.facebook.com/project.guwani)**
- **Research output file** (https://tinyurl.com/m4k2dyft)

See Also

- Pangalian Balindong
- Malabang, Lanao del Sur
- Picong, Lanao del Sur
- Sultan Kudarat
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Mah'ad Lanao al-Islamia
- 1976 Tripoli Agreement

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